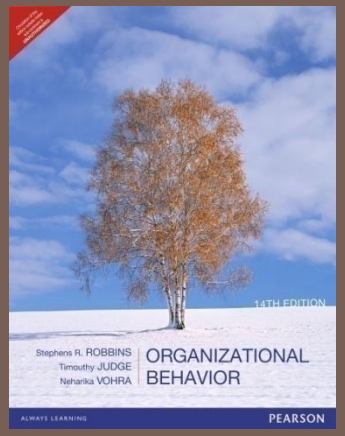

ORGANIZATIONAL BEHAVIOR

Robbins, Judge, and Vohra
Organizational Behavior
14th Edition

Diversity in Organizations

Reference: Robbins, Judge, and Vohra Organizational Behavior, 14th Edition
Dorling Kindersley (India) Pvt. Ltd, Authorized adaptation from the United States edition of *Organizational Behavior, 14e*

Lesson 2

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Chapter Learning Objectives

- After studying this chapter, you should be able to:
  - Describe the two major forms of workforce diversity.
  - Define the key biographical characteristics and describe how they are relevant to OB.
  - Define intellectual ability and demonstrate its relevance to OB.
  - Contrast the two types of ability.
  - Describe how organizations manage diversity effectively.
  - Show how culture affects our understanding of biographical characteristics and intellectual abilities.

Diversity

Everybody brings differences to an organization where they work. These differences can create energy and excitement in the workplace, but they can also cause conflict. So it is important that we have an understanding of how diversity works in organizations.

✓When we look at the workplace we can recognize two levels of diversity.

Surface-level diversity

Deep-level diversity

Diversity …

✓Surface-level diversity represents the characteristics that are easily observed such as race, gender, age etc.

✓Deep-level diversity represents the aspects that are more difficult to see at first glance such as values, personality, and work preferences.

✓Organizations need to engage in Diversity Management to eliminate unfair discrimination.
✓By understanding what diversity is and helping employees with training and development opportunities, the negative impact of discrimination can be minimized.

Biographical Characteristics

- Biographical characteristics represent many of the surface-level aspects of diversity. These are characteristics that are very easy to identify.
  - age, gender, and race. It can also include tenure, religion, sexual orientation, and gender identity

Objective and easily obtained personal characteristics.

- **Age**
  - Age is an increasingly relevant characteristic as the workforce is aging. Older workers bring with them a wealth of knowledge and experience, but the perception is that productivity often declines with age. Whether this is true or not, it is a perception people act upon and will impact the workplace.
    - (Older workers bring experience, judgment, a strong work ethic, and commitment to quality.)

Biographical Characteristics

- **Gender**
  - In studying gender in the workplace, it has been found that there are very few differences between men and women that impact job performance. However, women, especially those with pre-school age children, do prefer flexible work schedules and will seek an employer who offers options in their schedules.
    - (Few differences between men and women that affect job performance.)

Biographical Characteristics …

- Race and Ethnicity offers little explanation for differentials in workplace outcomes. It has been shown, however, that people in the workplace do identify more with people like themselves so in some cases there may be opportunities given to people based on the fact that they are like their supervisor.

- Disability (slide 23)
  - Today's organizations have started making efforts to hire people with disabilities.
    - Eg: Central Bank of Sri Lanka
    - Universities (Colombo/Peradeniya)

Biographical Characteristics …

- Tenure[1]
- Tenure refers to the length of time people have been on the job and is tied to seniority.
- Often, tenure is seen as a positive as it signifies that people are happy with their employment because they have remained in their job for a long period of time
- Therefore, employees with long tenure tend to be more productive, call in sick less frequently, and don't leave the organization as readily.
  - (People with job tenure (seniority at a job) are more productive, absent less frequently, have lower turnover, and are more satisfied.)

[1]: Tenure: The period of time when sb holds an important job

Other Biographical Characteristics

- Religion
  - May impact the workplace in areas of dress, grooming, and scheduling. The law prohibits employers from discriminating against employees on the basis of their religion.
  - Schedules may also conflict with the way work is typically done, such as a Muslim worker adhering to the prayer schedule outlined in Islam.
- Sexual Orientation
  - Sexual Orientation and Gender Identity are not protected by federal law and as a result they are handled differently by most employers. Often, these characteristics are dealt with just as if they were protected characteristics in order to discourage discriminatory behavior, whether it is covered by the law or not.
    - (In June 2009, the High Court of Delhi, in a landmark judgment, decriminalized homosexual sex between consenting adults, overturning a 149-year-old British colonial law)
  - Domestic partner benefits are an important consideration.

Other Biographical Characteristics

- Gender Identity
  - Relatively new issue – transgendered employees.

- Companies try to create cultures that provide a safe environment for all employees and cultures free of discriminatory behavior.

Ability –(Deep-level)

Ability is defined as an individual's capacity to perform the various tasks associated with the job.

- Intellectual (This is the ability to perform mental activities.)
- Physical Abilities

Ability

- Made up of two sets of factors:
  - Intellectual Abilities
    - The abilities needed to perform mental activities.
    - General Mental Ability (GMA) is a measure of overall intelligence.
    - No correlation between intelligence and job satisfaction.

There are a number of measures of intellectual ability available for use by organizations. Two representative measures are the GMA (General Mental Ability) measure and the Wonderlic Personnel Test. The GMA takes a look at overall intelligence and is generally recognized by researchers. The Wonderlic is generally used as a quick measure of intelligence in the hiring process. Often, it takes less than ten minutes to complete. Depending on the requirements of the job, intelligence tests can be used to predict success on certain job tasks. However, there has been no correlation found between intelligence and job satisfaction.

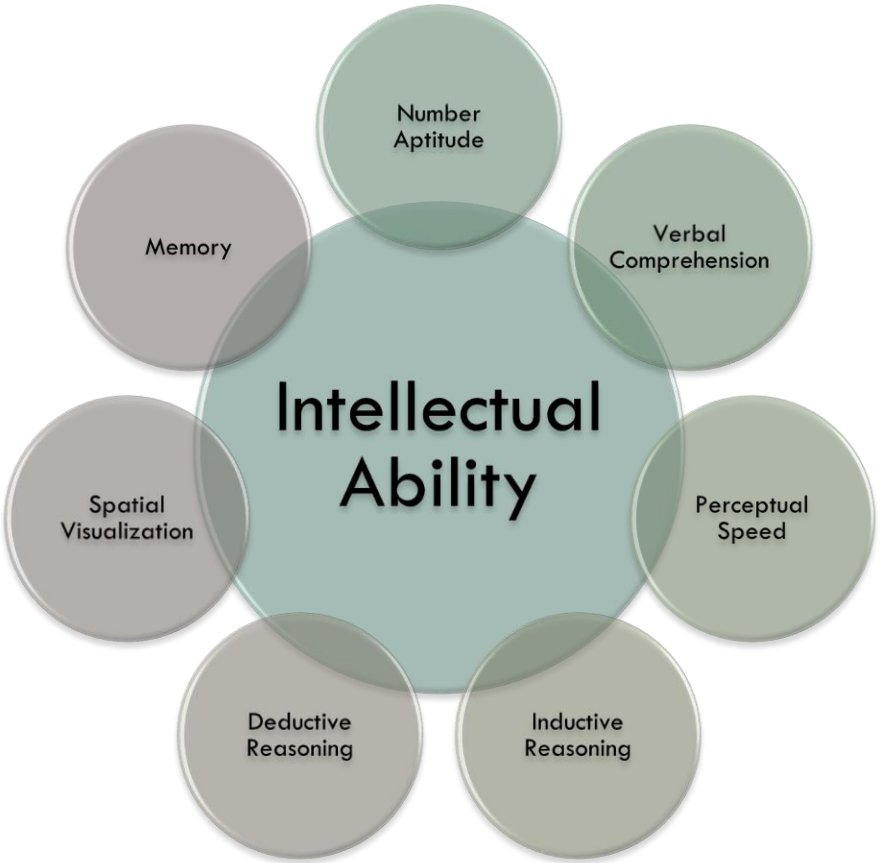
Ability

- Made up of two sets of factors:
  - Physical Abilities
    - The capacity to do tasks demanding stamina, dexterity, strength, and similar characteristics.

Physical Ability is the second factor of ability and represents the capacity to do tasks that demand stamina, dexterity, strength, and other characteristics related to performance of physical tasks.

Dimensions of Intellectual Ability

Intellectual ability is made up of many dimensions. They include number aptitude, verbal comprehension, perceptual speed, inductive reasoning, deductive reasoning, spatial visualization, and memory.



See E X H I B I T 2–3 for details

Dimensions of Intellectual Ability

Exhibit 2-3 Dimensions of Intellectual Ability

Dimension	Description	Job Example
Number aptitude	Ability to do speedy and accurate arithmetic	Accountant: Computing the sales tax on a set of items
Verbal comprehension	Ability to understand what is read or heard and the relationship of words to each other	Plant manager: Following corporate policies on hiring
Perceptual speed	Ability to identify visual similarities and differences quickly and accurately	Fire investigator: Identifying clues to support a charge of arson
Inductive reasoning	Ability to identify a logical sequence in a problem and then solve the problem	Market researcher: Forecasting demand for a product in the next time period
Deductive reasoning	Ability to use logic and assess the implications of an argument	Supervisor: Choosing between two different suggestions offered by employees
Spatial visualization	Ability to imagine how an object would look if its position in space were changed	Interior decorator: Redecorating an office
Memory	Ability to retain and recall past experiences	Salesperson: Remembering the names of customers

Dimensions of Intellectual Ability

✓Number aptitude is the ability to do speedy and accurate arithmetic and will be effective in jobs requiring mathematical ability, such as an accountant.

✓Verbal comprehension is the ability to understand what is read or heard and the relationship of words to each other. This ability will be helpful in jobs where the manager needs to understand policies in order to carry out their job tasks.

✓Perceptual speed is the ability to identify visual similarities and differences quickly and accurately. This particular ability is helpful when an employee needs to take in a lot of information and make decisions about the patterns, such as a detective or inspector.

✓Inductive reasoning is present when an individual can identify a logical sequence in a problem in order to help find a solution. An employee who needs to make decisions about the future based on historical information will need the ability of inductive reasoning.

Dimensions of Intellectual Ability

✓Deductive reasoning is the ability to use logic and assess the implications of the argument. When making choices between two different possible solutions to a problem, a manager would need to call upon their deductive reasoning skills.

✓Spatial Visualization is when someone can imagine how an object would look if its position in space was changed. An employee who needs to make decisions about office setup or interior design would need to have a high level of spatial visualization ability.

✓Memory is the ability to retain and recall past experiences. Individuals who need to act quickly in a situation, such as a paramedic or nurse, would need a significant degree of memory ability.

Nine Basic Physical Abilities

Exhibit 2-4 Nine Basic Physical Abilities

Strength Factors	
1. Dynamic strength	Ability to exert muscular force repeatedly or continuously over time
2. Trunk strength	Ability to exert muscular strength using the trunk (particularly abdominal) muscles
3. Static strength	Ability to exert force against external objects
4. Explosive strength	Ability to expend a maximum of energy in one or a series of explosive acts
Flexibility Factors	
5. Extent flexibility	Ability to move the trunk and back muscles as far as possible
6. Dynamic flexibility	Ability to make rapid, repeated flexing movements
Other Factors	
7. Body coordination	Ability to coordinate the simultaneous actions of different parts of the body
8. Balance	Ability to maintain equilibrium despite forces pulling off balance
9. Stamina	Ability to continue maximum effort requiring prolonged effort over time

Implementing Diversity Management Strategies

- Knowing that people are different is not enough for organizations to operate effectively with differences. Managers must work to develop strategies to develop ways to utilize differences to achieve work outcomes.
- Making everybody more aware and sensitive to the needs of others.

Role of Different Abilities

- When focusing on ability, it can create problems when attempting to develop workplace policies that recognize diversity in terms of disabilities.
- It is important to recognize diversity and strive for it in the hiring process.
- An organization needs to be careful to avoid discriminatory practices by making generalizations about people with different abilities.

Forms of Discrimination

Type of Discrimination	Definition	Examples from Organizations
Discriminatory policies or practices	Actions taken by representatives of the organization that deny equal opportunity to perform or unequal rewards for performance	Older workers may be targeted for layoffs because they are highly paid and have lucrative benefits.[8]
Sexual harassment	Unwanted sexual advances and other verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature that create a hostile or offensive work environment	At one company, the much-married boss asked a young woman team member to travel with him and then made sexual advances toward her at the hotel.[9]
Intimidation	Overt threats or bullying directed at members of specific groups of employees	Recently, many workers from Bihar and Uttar Pradesh were threatened, intimidated, and asked to leave Mumbai on the pretext that they were taking away jobs from the local people.
Mockery and insults	Jokes or negative stereotypes; sometimes the result of jokes taken too far	At a prestigious B-school, a student from a rural background, who spoke English with a very strong accent, was laughed at openly by his classmates everytime he spoke in class.
Exclusion	Exclusion of certain people from job opportunities, social events, discussions, or informal mentoring; can occur unintentionally	Many women in engineering claim they are assigned to marginal job roles or are given light workloads that don't lead to promotion.
Incivility	Disrespectful treatment, including behaving in an aggressive manner, interrupting the person, or ignoring his or her opinions	Female lawyers note that male attorneys frequently cut them off or do not adequately address their comments.[10]

Global Implications

- Biographical Characteristics
  - Not much evidence on the global relevance of the relationships described in this chapter.
  - Countries do vary dramatically on their biographical composition.

Additional Global Implications

- Intellectual Abilities
  - Structures and measures of intelligence generalize across cultures.
- Diversity Management
  - Diversity management is important across the globe. However, different cultures will use different frameworks for handling diversity.

Summary and Managerial Implications

- Summary:
  - Ability
    - Directly influences employee's level of performance.
    - Managers need to focus on ability in selection, promotion, and transfer.
    - Fine-tune job to fit incumbent's abilities.
  - Biographical Characteristics
    - Should not be used in management decisions: possible source of bias.

Summary and Managerial Implications

- **Diversity Management**

- Diversity Management is the application of the organization's understanding of diversity. It is the way that organizations recognize and utilize the differences that will allow them to create a culture that capitalizes on their workforce diversity to be a leader in the marketplace.

-
  - Must be an ongoing commitment at all levels of the organization.
  - Policies must include multiple perspectives and be long term in their orientation to be effective.